

YOUTH INTERNATIONAL PARTY LINE

REVISED

ISSUE NO. 2



JULY, 1971

'Blue Box' Is Linked to Phone Call Fraud

By ROY R. SILVER

Special to The New York Times

MINEOLA, L. I., May 5—

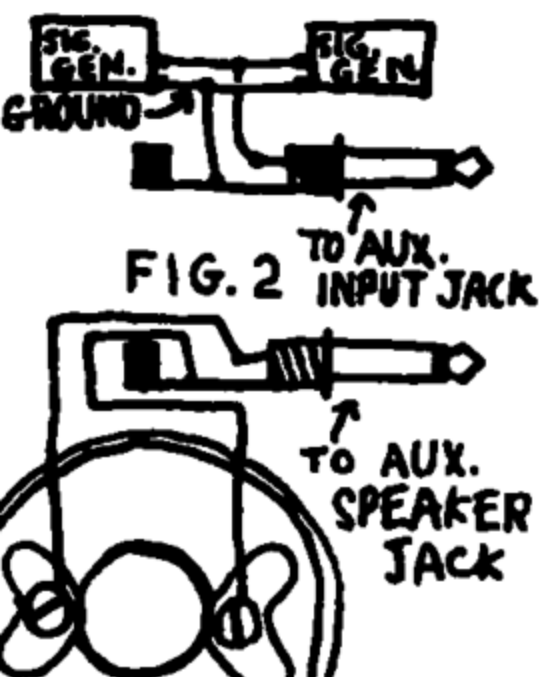
Armed with a court order, detectives of the prosecutor's rackets bureau and telephone company personnel searched the home at 26 Henhawk Road last night. They said they found a small box measuring 5 by 6 by 3½ inches attached to a telephone in the youth's room.

The prosecutor did not say who had made the box. The telephone company said similar devices had been used elsewhere in the country, before.

The telephone company became suspicious when computer cards showing the amount of time used for information calls indicated that some calls were taking much more than the usual one to three minutes.

1=700 + 900
2=700 + 1100
3=900 + 1100
4=700 + 1300
5=900 + 1300
6=1100 + 1300
7=700 + 1500
8=900 + 1500
9=1100 + 1500
0=1300 + 1500
KP=1100 + 1700
ST=1500 + 1700
Disconnect=2600

FIG. 1



by Al Bell

After interviewing engineering students around the country, I found that the blue box makes tones that are similar to, but not exactly like a pushbutton phone. Since operators use the same device for putting operator-assistance calls through, the tones were published in the Bell System Technical Journal, 1960. Large libraries and engineering schools have the Journal. Like a pushbutton phone, two frequencies make up each tone. One of the "boxers" who was not caught said, "Those people who were caught probably called information, 'bleeped' out the operator, and redirected the call with the box, by pressing the buttons of the desired number. I haven't been caught because I call from a pay phone, and I never stay on more than 15 minutes. Most importantly, I never use information. I use the Sheraton Hotels Watts Line number, 800-325-3535. Right before they answer, I bleep them out."

But the blue box isn't necessary. A cassette tape machine will work fine. Two signal generators are needed to record the pair of tones for each digit, start, and stop. Record each digit, & you will have a master tape from which to make actual phone number sequences on other machines. One signal generator will work if you make the master on a stereo tape, and play the two channels back together as you record them on the other tape.

For this to work, several rules must be followed:

- Record direct, without microphones, as in Fig. 1.
- Record as loud as possible without distortion. Watch your record meter when making tapes.
- Only use fresh batteries, and don't wear them out.
- A better speaker for playing the tones into phones is a standard telephone earpiece. Where you steal one is your problem, (its so easy) but plug it into the ext. speaker jack as in Fig.
- Each tone lasts one second, with one second between each tone. However, wait 3 seconds after "bleeping" disconnect tone. Then play KP, area code, number, and ST, in that order.
- Hold your little makeshift speaker close to mouthpiece without moving while playing tones.
- Your electronics friends and young engineers can help you get a signal generator or two to use, and they'll help you record the tones properly.
- The two frequencies of each tone must last the entire one second, and they must start and stop simultaneously.

CAUTION: YIPL does not advocate making free calls. However, YIPL doesn't believe in paying for calls, either. If caught, you may be charged with fraud and theft of services. So consider carefully whether you need to call long distance, and if you do,, consider whether or not you believe in free speech.

The Dumbest Rip-Off

By RUSSELL BAKER

OBSERVER

Dear Abbie (Hoffman, that is):

In reading your latest work, "Steal This Book," I had just gotten to the directions for cheating the telephone company when, following your command, somebody stole the book.

I didn't finish the telephone section and—careless me!—didn't even think to make notes. I do not even remember what size washers you recommended for dropping into pay telephone coin slots to simulate the real thing. What troubles me is something more fundamental. I wonder if you have really thought out the implications of the grand philosophical idea of destroying the telephone company, which underlies your discussion of techniques.

I suggest to you that it is simply not sound, that destroying the telephone company would, in fact, be a severe blow to every member of the counter-culture.

In the first place, you must have noticed, if you have been in England, France, Italy or Bulgaria, that it is extremely frustrating trying to get along in a country with no telephone system. The English will put up with that, the French and Italians will put up with it, and the Bulgarians will have to put up with it, but you know as well as I do, Abbie, that an American, particularly if he is in the counter-culture, needs a telephone the way a monkey needs a banana.

To the American counter-culturist, a telephone in the hand is as much a part of his uniform as denim, dried lentils and a coiffure from Michelangelo's Moses.

If we destroy the telephone company, who will be the first people to picket the Pentagon to demand a new telephone company? The members of the counter-culture; provided, of course, they can learn to communicate with each other without wires. A new telephone company will inevitably rise to take the place of the old evil telephone company.

There is no reason whatever to assume that the new telephone company will be like the old evil telephone company. There is every reason, on the contrary, to believe that it will profit from its predecessor's fatal errors and do things differently.

For example: Remember last summer when members of the counter-culture were telephoning each other across the continent and charging the calls to Paul Newman's credit-card number? Somebody — was it you, Abbie? — had said that Paul Newman was so angry with the telephone company that he had invited everybody in America to telephone across the continent, using his credit-card

number, so that when he received the bill he could show his irritation with the telephone company by refusing to pay it.

Well, counter-culturists galore phoned long distance, and the telephone company did not become angry. Not at all. It quietly traced each call back to the telephone of origin, often rousing some parent from his parental stupor.

"Those long-distance calls made from your telephone, apparently by your child," said the patient mechanical voices, "represent fraudulent use of a credit-card number belonging to the University of Illinois and not, as the gullible believed, to Paul Newman."

"Fraudulent—?"

"The crime is punishable by imprisonment of up to five years and—"

Well, where breathes there a parent so vile that he would send his heir to Leavenworth rather than pay a piffling \$300 to the telephone company?

The present telephone company is like that. It does not come knocking at the door with a truncheon and arrest warrant to haul away members of the counter-culture. It knows that money is most easily collected from people who are soft between the ears.

"Whether your child serves five years in Leavenworth is entirely up to you, as a parent. Your telephone company, sir, does not make threats."

The next telephone company is not

likely to be so indulgent as the present one collapsing its bill collection policy so heartedly. The new telephone company will almost surely put the counter-culture on trial for fraud, possibly before the Hoffman.

Can you really believe that the telephone company will let the present one's practice go? "Sure" when somebody's operator in Boston and to make \$800 worth of calls to the West Coast all charged to daddy's West Orange, N. J.?"

My bet, Abbie, is that to say, "After seeing the telephone company were of a bunch of cheating it a policy to call daddy if your calls are okay

Is that the kind of company that counter-culture A telephone company daddy into the system are made, instead of with an \$800 fait accompli later?

The present telephone the best of all possible companies for the Destroying it would put the hands of Mom and about it next time be for one of those wash

Dear folks,

I read your letter that was passed around on May Day. Please start sending me more, I'm very interested in fucking the fucking phone company. I'm mad. Well anyway, I've enclosed a cheque of 3 dollars; please find and send those little sheets as soon as possible. Thank you kindly. up the revo, K.O., Riverdale, Md.

Enclosed is \$1. Could you tell me the signs of a wire tap (hollowness & clicks?). Also, do you have the plans for a device that allows you to make long distance calls free? R.F., Norfolk, Va.

My friend, there is no sure way of detecting a tap. I view the telephone as a hot line to the pork factory. As far as plans, one guy did supply them until he got busted. Using info in this issue, consult a friend on power supplies (regulated) and oscillators.

While I was in D.C. for Mayday, I picked up some info on how to fuck the Bell system. I'm really interested in this because I know how true this all is because I was in the computer room of the phone company. I'm sending \$1 so that I can receive your newsletters. And if there is anything I can do for Y.I.P. just let me know. And there's any way of fucking up the govt. any other way, let me know. J.H., Pa.

Richard M. Nixon—El Presidente
202 456-1444

Spiro T. Agnew—El Toro
202 265-2000 Ext. 6400

John N. Hitchell—El Butcher
202 965-2900

Melvin R. Laird—El Defendo
301 652-4449

Henry A. Kissinger—El Exigente
202 337-0042

William P. Rogers—El Crapper
301 654-7125

General Earl G. Wheeler—El Joint Bosso
703 527-6119

Call collect, from a pay phone, people.

Dear Russel (Baker that is):

I just read your letter and was surprised you even saw Steal This Book since no major newspaper, including that well known spokesman for free speech, the New York Times, will accept an ad for the book. None-the-less, the boys down at AT&T must be happy to know they have a friend at the Times. It's true even us yippies don't wish to hatch our coast-to-coast conspiracies using dixie cups with waxed string stretched between them. But if our efforts to sabotage the phone company by teaching people how to make calls free are the "dumbest rip off" then AT&T itself must be engaged in the smartest rip off. Last year their revenues amounted to about 17 billion dollars, give or take a few dimes. They made a 7.6% rate of return on their bread, which in a recession is pretty damn good. To say they function as a cut throat monopoly would be understating the case. I refer you to the excellent book called "Monopoly" by Joseph C. Goulden (\$.95 Pocket Books) for a devastating account of the world's largest corporation. Witness their central role in the military-industrial complex! Laugh off their defiance of citizens and governmental attempts to hold down phone rates! Smile courteously when waiting three hours to complete your next long-distance call! Nod like a robot the next time they explain how they are controlled by their shareholders and customers! To defend their efficiency only leads me to believe you never use the phone. It's a bit unfair to compare the system here to Bulgaria or Greece or even an underdeveloped nation such as England. AT&T's current assets are estimated at 50 billion dollars, which is not exactly pocket change for most countries in the world. Even so, the systems of Sweden and Denmark seem to function better, especially with the speed in which they phase out obsolete equipment. I should also point out that Cuba has an entirely free phone system; and that, Russell, is the point of the whole monkey business of Steal This Book in general. Yuppies think you judge the goodness of nations by their goals. As the level of the technological development increases, the costs should decrease with the goal being to make everything produced in a society free to all the people, come who may. Neat, huh? Until AT&T and the other corporations really become public services rather than power and profit gobblers, we'll continue to rip them off every chance we get. If you want to discuss this further, call me up sometime. Because of all the agencies claiming to have me under surveillance, it's one of the fastest ways to speak directly to your government.

Your voice with a smile,

Abbie Hoffman

STRIKE THE



WAR MACHINE

Assignment: Monitor the telephone in the suite of Senator Eugene McCarthy at the 1968 Democratic Convention. Agents reported that McCarthy had made a phone call to a "known leftist organization" offering medical help to wounded demonstrators. -Life Magazine study of Army "Intelligence"

In addition to manufacturing Princess telephones, Western Electric makes guided missiles and is a prominent member of the military-industrial complex which so frightened President Eisenhower that he warned against its "acquisition of unwarranted influence" in his farewell address. An examination of Western Electric's defense work shows that the President had ample reason for alarm. Through adept use of a technique called profit pyramiding in the defense industry, Western Electric ran up profits of 31.3 percent on its major missile contracts, while helping the Pentagon accumulate military junk that was never used. ~~Monopoly~~, by Joseph C. Goulden

Editors Note: We intend to show, through statements such as the above two, how the Bell System has become anti-human to its customers, employees, and just about everyone else. However, it should be noted that these statements are taken out of context, and do not do justice to the case. The whole story is a lot scarier than just a "profit-gobbler". It's a question of accumulation of power and securing that power. You know, great that people are being monitored, but shit, people are being slaughtered. All in the name of money. And since we give them the money, we are at fault. Stop paying and start yelling. See ya next month, phreeks.

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y i p i

TO:

IF WE HELP YOU TO
THE GOVERNMENT
GOVERNMENT
SAVE MONEY.
WE'D LOVE IT IF YOU COULD SEND US MONEY OR STAMPS
PUSHES SPEED
IS GETTING
& SMACK
RICHER